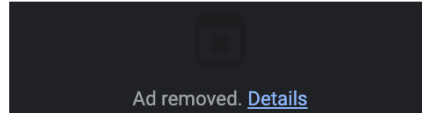


[AllMusic Review](#)[User Reviews](#)[Track Listing](#)[Credits](#)[Releases](#)[Similar Albums](#)[Moods and Themes](#)

Surrounded Review by AllMusic



Surrounded Review by [Fred Thomas](#)

On their debut full-length, *Surrounded*, Toronto-bred trio Motorists hit a sweet spot that intersects the wistful jangle and chorus-drenched guitar work of classic '80s college rock bands with healthy amounts of post-punk-leaning frustration and energy. Made up of longtime friends and collaborators [Craig Fahner](#), [Matt Learoyd](#), and [Jesse Locke](#), the band writes songs that are both snappy and to the point while being layered with both musical intricacies and understated social critique. *Surrounded*'s title track follows a perpetually dissatisfied narrator as they go from one environment to another, finding new problems living in the city, the country, and communal spaces, ultimately feeling crowded and overwhelmed by existence itself. It's a wildly neurotic lyrical journey that plays out over a relatively fun and upbeat instrumental. Album standout "Vainglorious" taps into the 12-string jangle of bands like [Felt](#), [Josef K](#), and even hints of early [R.E.M.](#), creating a wistful melancholy with its interlocking melodies and dynamic shifts. Much of *Surrounded* finds its rhythm somewhere between softly depressed college rock songwriting and mildly agitated post-punk uproar, but there are also hints of other impulses that peek through at times. "Latent Space" begins with a motorik verse made up of phased-out guitars and psychedelically tinged vocal harmonies. The same Krautrock influences that bands like [Garcia Peoples](#) or [Sunwatchers](#) blend into their sounds come through in Motorists' moments like this, sounding like a punk band who simultaneously just discovered [Phish](#) and [Popol Vuh](#). Cosmic undercurrents and post-punk dissonance also clash intriguingly in songs like "New Day" and the euphoric buildup that grows blindingly powerful on album closer "The Door," but Motorists are quick to temper their more untethered moments with clean and concise melodic rockers like the [Orange Juice](#)-esque "Turn It Around" or the moody, twinkling power pop of "Through to You." The record is built on an abundance of thoughtfully arranged hooks, much like some of the albums the band takes notes from. Similar to early [Elvis Costello](#) records, [Fables of the Reconstruction](#), or any number of inspired releases from Scottish indie pop acts of the early '80s, *Surrounded* is so overflowing with life that it demands repeated spins to truly take it all in. With songs this strong, however, repeat listening is hardly a problem.